

Daily Content Intel

July 8, 2026

Topic A — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, there's a new study out of a high performance sports school that tracked 26 young athletes for 8 weeks, and it found something every coach and parent should hear. When practice or training ended after 8:30 at night, those kids got significantly less total sleep. And every extra 10 minutes of training in a day chipped away a little more sleep on top of that.

Here's why I care. Sleep is where the adaptation happens. It's when the nervous system resets, tissue repairs, and the work your athlete put in on the field actually turns into speed and strength. Short that window and you're

training hard for a smaller return, and you're walking into the next session under recovered, which is exactly when the soft tissue injuries tend to show up.

The researchers were blunt about the fix. Finish training by 8:30 so the athlete can still get a minimum of 8 hours. That's it.

So Monday, here's what I'd do. If practice runs late, protect the back end of the night. Lights out on a schedule, no late film, no late scrolling. And if you control the calendar, pull the session earlier or trim the tail end of a long night. Speed of movement in the weight room, quality reps on the field, none of it sticks if the athlete isn't sleeping.

Does that make sense? The cheapest performance upgrade your athlete has is the one that's free.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Want your athlete faster and more durable? Start by looking at what time practice actually ends.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, there's a new study out of a high performance sports school that tracked 26 young athletes for 8 weeks, and it found something every coach and parent should hear. When practice or training ended after 8:30 at night, those kids got significantly less total sleep. And every extra 10 minutes of training in a day chipped away a little more sleep on top of that.

Here's why I care. Sleep is where the adaptation happens. It's when the nervous system resets, tissue repairs, and the work your athlete put in on the field actually turns into speed and strength. Short that window and you're training hard for a smaller return, and you're walking into the next session under recovered, which is exactly when the soft tissue injuries tend to show up.

The researchers were blunt about the fix. Finish training by 8:30 so the athlete can still

get a minimum of 8 hours. That's it.

So Monday, here's what I'd do. If practice runs late, protect the back end of the night. Lights out on a schedule, no late film, no late scrolling. And if you control the calendar, pull the session earlier or trim the tail end of a long night. Speed of movement in the weight room, quality reps on the field, none of it sticks if the athlete isn't sleeping.

Does that make sense? The cheapest performance upgrade your athlete has is the one that's free.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 What time does practice end?
- 0:05 26 young athletes, tracked 8 weeks
- 0:12 Training past 8:30pm = significantly less sleep
- 0:20 Sleep is where adaptation happens
- 0:32 Under-recovered = when injuries show up
- 0:42 The fix: finish by 8:30, protect 8 hours

- 0:55 Lights out on a schedule
- 1:05 Free performance upgrade

Caption (copy-paste ready):

The single cheapest way to make your athlete faster and harder to injure is the clock. Specifically, what time practice ends.

A 2025 study tracked 26 young athletes for 8 weeks. When training ended after 8:30 at night, they got significantly less total sleep. Every extra 10 minutes of daily training cost a little more on top of that.

Sleep is where the work turns into speed and strength. It's when the nervous system resets and tissue repairs. Short the window and you train hard for a smaller return, then walk into the next session under recovered.

The researchers said it plainly: finish training by 8:30 so athletes can still get at least 8 hours. Protect the back end of the night. Pull late sessions earlier when you can.

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#athletedevelopment #sleepandperformance
#youthsports #footballtraining #lacrosse
#recovery #strengthandconditioning
#returntosport #sportsperformance
#injuryprevention

Personalize this

- Which of your HS football or lacrosse athletes are on late-night practice or club schedules that push bedtime past 10, and what have you seen in their durability or speed on the field because of it?
- When you build a return-to-sport plan at Threshold, how do you factor sleep and recovery load alongside the strength and change-of-direction criteria you already track?
- Do you have a story of an athlete whose performance jumped once they fixed sleep, and how does that tie into the Recover pillar of your CROSS framework?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12592842/> | "The influence of

training load and schedule on youth athletes' sleep"

- physiology | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12592842/> | "Youth athletes who finished training after 20:30 hours had significantly less total sleep time than when training finished before 20:30 hours."
- actionable | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12592842/> | "These data should be used by coaches and sports administrators to advocate for the need to finish training sessions for youth athletes by 20:30 hours to enable them to achieve a minimum 8 hr sleep."

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12592842/>
- <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/jsr.70013>

Topic B — Reel

TELEPROMPTER COPY (paste into Instagram)

Okay, hot take. If your plan for building an athlete's engine is hours of slow Zone 2 or endless gassers until someone throws up, you're spending a whole lot of time for a small return.

Here's what the research keeps showing. A 2025 meta-analysis of 23 studies in kids and teens found that low volume, high intensity intervals produced a big jump in VO2 max, and the effect was right in line with long steady state cardio, in a fraction of the time. Short, hard, organized. Same engine, way less clock.

And this matters for a field sport athlete even more than for an endurance guy. Football and lacrosse are stop and go. A hard effort, a rest, a hard effort, a rest, over and over. The aerobic engine is what refills the tank between those

efforts, so your athlete is just as fast on the last rep as the first. Dr. Mike T Nelson calls this smart cardio for lifters who don't want to lose their gains, and I think that framing fits athletes too. You build the engine, and you don't torch the legs the day before practice.

So Monday, I'd keep the base easy and short a few days a week, then add one real interval day. Something like 4 rounds of 3 to 4 minutes hard with full recovery. Build the engine, keep the legs, save the field for the sport.

That's my take. Steady state still earns a spot in the week. I'd just spend more of the budget on short, hard work.

Be Good. Help Someone. Learn Lots.

Hook: Here's my hot take: those endless conditioning gassers are a low-return way to build an athlete's engine.

Spoken script (word for word):

Okay, hot take. If your plan for building an athlete's engine is hours of slow Zone 2 or endless gassers until someone throws up, you're spending a whole lot of time for a small return.

Here's what the research keeps showing. A 2025 meta-analysis of 23 studies in kids and teens found that low volume, high intensity intervals produced a big jump in VO2 max, and the effect was right in line with long steady state cardio, in a fraction of the time. Short, hard, organized. Same engine, way less clock.

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That's my take. Steady state still earns a spot in the week. I'd just spend more of the budget on short, hard work.

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On-screen text seeds:

- 0:00 Hot take: gassers are a low-return engine builder
- 0:08 2025 meta: 23 studies, kids and teens
- 0:15 Short intervals = big VO2 max jump
- 0:22 Same engine as steady-state, less time
- 0:30 Your sport is stop-and-go, all game
- 0:40 The engine refills the tank between reps
- 0:52 One real interval day: 4 x 3-4 min hard

- 1:05 Build the engine, keep the legs

Caption (copy-paste ready):

Building an athlete's engine does not require hours of slow cardio or gassers until someone pukes. That's a lot of clock for a small return.

A 2025 meta-analysis of 23 studies in kids and teens found low volume, high intensity intervals produced a big jump in VO2 max, with effects right in line with long steady state cardio in a fraction of the time.

This matters more for a field sport athlete than for an endurance runner. Football and lacrosse are a hard effort, a rest, repeated all game. The aerobic engine is what refills the tank between reps, so your athlete is as fast on the last one as the first.

So keep the base easy and short a few days a week, then add one real interval day.

Something like 4 rounds of 3 to 4 minutes hard with full recovery. Build the engine, keep the legs, save the field for the sport.

Steady state still earns a spot. I'd just spend more of the budget on short, hard work.

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#conditioning #vo2max #footballtraining
#lacrosse #strengthandconditioning
#athletedevelopment #hiit #zone2
#sportsperformance #offseasontraining

Personalize this

- How do you build conditioning into your HS football and lacrosse athletes' weeks without frying their legs before practice, and where does one hard interval day land in your in-season vs offseason split?
- Have you had an athlete whose late-game or fourth-quarter drop-off traced back to a poor aerobic base, and how did you rebuild it at Threshold?
- Do you use any hop, change-of-direction under fatigue, or repeat-effort testing to show an athlete their engine improved, since you don't use force plates?

Screenshots:

- title | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12757267/> | "Is low-volume high

intensity interval training a time-efficient strategy for improving body composition and cardiovascular health in children and adolescents?"

- physiology | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12757267/> | "LV-HIIT produced a significant improvement in VO₂max, with moderate heterogeneity among studies (K = 10, g = 1.35, 95% CI [0.75, 1.94])"
- actionable | <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12757267/> | "LV-HIIT can effectively and time-efficiently improve body composition and cardiovascular health in children and adolescents, with overall effects comparable to MICT."

Sources:

- <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12757267/>
- <https://miketnelson.com/flexible-meathead-cardio>

Reference

Runner-up topics

- Youth sprint force-velocity profiles and maturity status (Sports Biomechanics 2026) — prescribe sled load by where the athlete is on the FV curve.
- Velocity-based training loss thresholds in adolescent sprinters — how much bar-speed drop before you stop the set.
- Eccentric hamstring strength normative data in 590 youth athletes — screening cutoffs by body mass.

Sources scanned today

- Newsletter digest (2026-07-08): Mike T. Nelson "The question you should ask" — build an aerobic engine for lifters/athletes, drop Zone 2 as the main plan, short daily cardio plus one VO2 interval day. Strong hot-take seed. Dr. Mercola "Is This Organ Quietly Working Against Your Heart" — pure promo/scare, skipped.
- PubMed / Journal of Sleep Research: Tate et al. 2025, training load and schedule vs youth athletes' sleep (26

youth athletes, 8 weeks). Used for Draft A.

- Frontiers in Physiology 2025: Zheng et al. three-level meta-analysis, low-volume HIIT in children and adolescents (23 studies, 996 participants). Used for Draft B.
- miketnelson.com Flexible Meathead Cardio page — secondary source for Draft B framing.
- Also surfaced but not used this round: youth sprint force-velocity + maturity (Sports Biomechanics 2026), velocity-based training thresholds in adolescent sprinters, eccentric hamstring normative data. Held for runner-ups.